

Radiator ears

Compared to other animals, mammals often have eye-catching ears. The blacktailed jackrabbit's are some of the biggest relative to its body, measuring half its length from head to tail. They are very effective at collecting sound, but they are not only used for hearing.

This jackrabbit lives in the deserts of western North America, where summer temperatures often climb above 104°F (40°C). Resting in the shade, it uses its ears like radiators to stop its body from overheating.



Network of blood vessels helps ears to radiate heat away from body



Full frontal

Like its body, an African elephant's ears are built on a giant scale. Elephants use them for hearing, keeping cool, and showing their mood. If they feel threatened, they spread them wide—a sign that they are ready to charge. Elephants communicate not only by trumpeting, but also with infrasound—sound so deep that humans cannot hear it. Infrasound waves travel through the ground as well as through the air.



Eardrum on each side of abdomen

Cicada

The male cicada's ears are shaped in a way that keeps it from being deafened by its own piercing calls.



Ear flap, or pinna, channels sound waves toward the eardrum, hidden inside the head

Inside ears

Swiveling on its head, the fennec fox's ears are alert to the faintest sounds. In addition to being big on the outside, its ears have an extra-large space shaped like a bubble, which separates the eardrum from the innermost part of the ear. This space works like an amplifier, helping sound waves to resonate. The fennec fox hunts after dark in the Sahara Desert and uses its ears to pinpoint insects and rodents as they scuttle across the ground.